the head of the SED Party organisation, Honecker had systematically consolidated his position and was able to hear the latest gossip, research intrigues, and use the insights gained when dealing with the SED's provincial satraps. This detailed knowledge, primarily of the weaknesses of his co-functionaries, was filed in an up-to-date card index – a resource that gave him a dominant position in the Politburo.

He was frank when meeting the salt of the Party but had enough nous to publicly support Ulbricht's line. Later, though not at the time, there would be intense interest from Bonn in Honecker's place in the GDR hierarchy. Incoming despatches to the West German intelligence agency, BND, recorded:

Opinions differ on Honecker's personality and abilities. On the one hand, he is characterised as an 'apparatchik' and a 'record player' who is not very intelligent but is always compliant due to his ambition, which makes him appear primarily suitable for control functions and would thus stamp him as the 'number two' in the regime. On the other hand, however, there is talk of Honecker's instinct for political connections which paired with considerable ruthlessness enables him to appear with an air of unsophisticated self-assurance.

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Interestingly, during 1963 the Berlin pro-opposition newspaper Telegraf speculated that SED key officials were discussing a replacement for Ulbricht. Honecker, according to the paper, was no longer mentioned as a possible successor but Paul Verner was. The Soviets, on their part, brought Paul Wandel into the discussion. Wandel, a former GDR ambassador to China, was regarded as a special confidant of Khrushchev. According to the Telegraf, the discussion of such possibilities showed the extent of insecurity